

Lowering CO2 standards for cars can cost lives

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-08-20 14:02

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with MARTINA SAPIO and TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — The Commission

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SNEAK PEEK

— The Commission's proposed reform weakening CO2 emission targets for automakers will lead to thousands more premature deaths, according to a new report.

— European air traffic controllers continue to keep delays below last summer's levels, although the improvement is beginning to slow.

— Vehicles are a major sticking point in trade negotiations between the U.S. and Canada.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

DANGER FROM WEAKER CO2 STANDARDS: The European Commission's proposed reform weakening emission standards for automakers will cause 6,800 additional premature deaths across the EU between 2025 and 2050, argues a study from the International Council on Clean Transportation released this week .

Reminder: The Commission's proposal would allow the sale of new combustion engine vehicles past 2035, including hybrids, as long as automakers offset the additional CO2 emissions through investments in things like alternative fuels and green steel. The industry and its right-leaning political allies want the standards to be even more flexible as negotiations in the EU institutions restart this fall.

More air pollution: Road transport is a leading contributor to air pollution across the EU, which can damage the human respiratory system. Under the Commission's proposal, ICCT projects that vehicles will emit 24 percent more carbon monoxide, 22 percent more volatile organic compounds and 4 percent more particulate matter between 2025 and 2050.

Needed reform: The Commission should update the Euro 7 emission standard for cars to combat the additional air pollution and account for combustion engine vehicles staying on Europe's roads longer, ICCT argues. The Euro 7 standard sets limits on how much particulate matter, carbon monoxide and

nitrogen dioxide a car can emit.

An uphill battle: Updating the standards would not be a simple task, however. Euro 7 proved to be an explosive file in both the European Parliament and among the EU's capitals. In the end, it largely kept the same car emission standards as under Euro 6. Automakers argued that any update to the emission standards would prove costly at a time when the industry was shifting toward electric vehicles.

Therein lies the problem: Automakers are "arguing both sides" by pushing for the CO2 standards to be weakened while simultaneously stating "they don't need to have stringent Euro 7 limits because they're moving toward electrification," Eamonn Mulholland, the ICCT report's lead author, told Jordyn.

AVIATION

ATC DELAY REDUCTION FALLS BELOW 20 PERCENT: The latest weekly data from Eurocontrol show that delays due to air traffic control remain below last summer's levels, although the improvement is beginning to slow. Air traffic flow management delays were 19 percent lower than a year ago, down from a 25 percent reduction reported two weeks ago. Arrival punctuality also eased, with year-on-year improvement falling to 1.9 percentage points, from 2.5 percentage points earlier this summer.

Still a solid summer: The figures remain encouraging for Eurocontrol and Europe's air traffic management sector, which continues to handle "traffic peaks of around 37,500 flights expected on Fridays," the network manager said.

The usual suspects: France remained the biggest source of air traffic delays, accounting for 32 percent of all en-route delays recorded so far this year. Spain followed with 17 percent, and Greece with 12 percent, Eurocontrol said.

JET FUEL PRICES CLIMB: Airlines are facing renewed pressure from fuel markets. According to Eurocontrol, jet fuel prices reached \$3.90 per gallon on Aug. 14, up 8.2 percent from the previous week.

Bad news for airlines: Although prices remain well below the more than \$5 per gallon recorded between March and April, the latest increase marks a reversal after jet fuel briefly fell below \$3 per gallon in June.

STARLINK DEBUTS ON LUFTHANSA: A Lufthansa flight from Frankfurt to Rome on Wednesday was the first with Starlink-powered high-speed internet as the German carrier joined the growing list of airlines using the service.

Rollout begins: Wednesday's flight by an Airbus A320neo is part of a wider rollout. Lufthansa plans to equip up to 10 additional A320-family aircraft by the end of the year. The longer-term goal is to install Starlink connectivity on around 850 aircraft across the Lufthansa Group by 2029.

Online — but quietly: While high-speed Wi-Fi may be welcomed by many passengers, others worry it will encourage rude behavior from travelers watching videos or making calls. "Passengers are required to always wear headphones when playing audio and video content, to refrain from making voice and video calls, and not to broadcast live streams from aboard the aircraft," Lufthansa said in a recent statement.

A growing club: According to StarlinkFlights.com, an online tracker, four carriers have already completed full Starlink installations, including Latvia's airBaltic. Another 17 airlines are rolling out the system, including Air France, SAS, British Airways, Aer Lingus and Iberia. Other European carriers that

have announced Starlink partnerships include Wizz Air, Vueling and Lufthansa Group airlines Eurowings, Brussels Airlines, Swiss and ITA Airways.

Offline nostalgia: The Atlantic recently argued that “air travel will never be the same” once reliable in-flight internet becomes the norm. “Planes were a bastion of unreachability. And once that luxury is gone, we may miss it,” the magazine wrote.

CARS

CARS STUCK IN THE MIDDLE OF U.S.-CANADA TRADE SPAT: President Donald Trump announced he would delay the new 50 percent tariffs on some Canadian goods to the end of this week. While Trump posted on social media that a deal had been reached between the U.S. and Ottawa, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said that “there is important work still to be done.”

The issue: Vehicles are proving to be a major sticking point in the talks, our U.S. colleague Oliver Ward reports.

What’s this about: Tariffs on some \$20 billion worth of Canadian exports are set to take effect this week if a deal isn’t finalized. Ottawa wants reductions in the 25 percent auto tariffs the U.S. imposed in 2025 and wants the duty to apply only to vehicle content produced outside of North America, one person familiar with the discussions told our U.S. trade colleagues.

Reminder: The automotive sector has a highly intertwined supply chain across Canada, the U.S. and Mexico, with parts or vehicles passing borders multiple times before showing up at a dealership. Trump’s trade war has put that arrangement into jeopardy and raised costs across the industry.

European automakers not immune: While German automakers have more manufacturing in Mexico, French-Italian-American automaker Stellantis has factories in Canada. After Trump’s initial tariffs, the automaker announced a €60 billion investment plan in the U.S. that was seen as a bid to placate the president.

Potential closures: Stellantis informed its workers’ union in Canada earlier this month of its plans to potentially sell its Brampton production facility. The factory was supposed to produce the Jeep Compass until Stellantis announced last year that production would be relocated to the U.S.

On the “right side”: Indian-owned automaker Jaguar Land Rover, meanwhile, told investors earlier this month that it needs to get production on “the right side of the tariff barrier.” It signed an agreement with Stellantis in May to use its American factories to produce vehicles like its popular luxury off-road Defender. JLR currently exports cars to the U.S.

TRUCKING

CHINA LEADS IN ELECTRIFYING TRUCKS: Sales of electric trucks and buses increased 86 percent year-over-year in 2025, led by China where nearly 30 percent of heavy truck sales were electric, according to the latest ICCT data out today and seen ahead of time by POLITICO. “In a sector traditionally defined by low profit margins, the long-term economic case for battery electric trucks is becoming clear, and China offers lessons to draw from,” ICCT researcher Shiyue Mao said in a statement.

Medium trucks on the rise: Overall electric truck sales in the EU grew 71 percent in 2025 compared to 2024, reaching 4.5 percent market share, the report states. Electric medium-sized trucks proved more popular, with their market share increasing from 10 percent in 2024 to 21 percent in 2025.

PIT STOPS

Chinese autonomous driving company Pony.ai told investors it plans to deploy more than 4,000 robotaxis overseas. Reuters has more .

Since May 2022, EU Solidarity Lanes have allowed Ukraine to export some 230 million tons of goods and to import 111 million tons of goods, such as fuel, vehicles, fertilizers as well as military and humanitarian assistance.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

One beneficiary of the Iran war? Pirates.

The Iran war is pulling naval resources toward the Middle East, creating an opening for Somali pirates to return — and adding another costly threat to strained global shipping routes.

By Scott Waldman · Aug 19, 2026, 11:16 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU moves to ease subsidy rules for small media

Revised state aid rules prioritize SMEs, innovation and social inclusion.

By Francesca Micheletti · Aug 19, 2026, 04:43 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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